

of changing your preferences. Some changes in the preferences can be helpful. Proceed to the preferences screen by clicking 'Change Preferences'. The first two options relate to the animated character, which you can change or disable. The most important option in the preferences is the Indexing Service. Turning this option On will enable file indexing when the system is idle. File indexing is a method by which an OS keeps a record—sort of a database—of all the files on your hard disk. When a search is initiated, it first scans this database file and verifies if the file still exists on the hard disk, thus saving time and system resources. System resources are used only when the search entry is not found in the database file, upon which it searches through the hard disk. This, naturally, consumes system memory and time, depending on the size of the partition being scanned.

Other options include changing the 'Files and Folders search behaviour' and 'Internet search behaviour'. Both options deal with the method by which you can choose to search for files. For instance, you can opt for 'Advanced Search' in 'Files and Folders behaviour' or change 'Internet search behaviour' to use Google.com instead of MSN.com. Apart from these options, you can choose to enable or disable balloon tips and auto complete.

To begin searching, choose any of the options (from Pictures, Documents, etc.) on the main page. Let's take 'All files and folders': all you need to do is type in the file name (see search tips below) and/or enter a keyword that the file may contain.

Search Tips:

- m If you do not remember the file name but you know what the file extension is, you can use special characters. Say you're looking for an executable (.exe) file, and you remember that the filename begins with, say, "G", then you can enter the search word as "G*.exe". This will search for files that have the .exe extension and also begin with the letter G. You



The search feature in XP has an animated character called the Search Companion